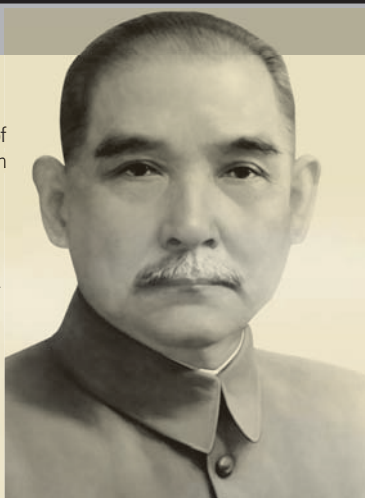


CHINESE NATIONALIST LEADER (1866–1925)

SUN YAT-SEN

Often referred to as “the Father of Modern China,” Sun Yat-sen was the leader of the National People’s Party (Kuomintang). Sun became the first president of the Republic of China in 1912 when he returned from 16 years of exile to overthrow the failing Manchu dynasty. He quickly lost power again and spent the following years fighting the warlords who controlled much of the country, making an alliance with the newly formed Communist Party. He died from cancer before he was able to consolidate his power and reunify China.

Sun became the symbol of Chinese modernization after his death due to his unrivaled knowledge of the West and determination to develop China. Uniquely, he is now revered in both mainland China and Taiwan.



1930–34 Mao Zedong formulates his strategy of a peasant-led revolution.

1931 Japan invades Manchuria.

1934 Chiang forces the CCP out of its southern bases. Start of the 7,450-mile (12,000-km) Long March as the Red Armies of the CCP retreat.

1935 Long March ends in Yanan, Shaanxi province, as the CCP relocates its power base from the southeast to the northwest. Of the 100,000 who had started the march, only 8,000 remain. Mao, who lost a brother and two young children in the Long March, becomes leader of the CCP.

1937–45 In a war against Japan, the CCP Red Army fights in the north, the Kuomintang in the south. Japan is defeated.

1945–49 War between Red Army and Kuomintang. US-backed Kuomintang retreats to Taiwan.

1949 Mao proclaims the People’s Republic of China on October 1.

1950 Chinese invasion of Tibet. Mutual assistance treaty with USSR.

1950–58 Land reform culminates in the setting up of communes. First five-year plan (1953–58) fails.



Little red thoughts

Teenage members of the Red Guard (above) read the thoughts of Chairman Mao from the Little Red Book. They were encouraged to humiliate their elders in a campaign against the “Four Olds.”

1956 Chinese characters are simplified in an attempt to promote literacy. There is a second round of simplification in 1964.

1958 “Great Leap Forward” to boost production fails. Farming is collectivized and this contributes to millions of deaths during the 1959–61 famine. Just two years into the five-year plan, it is abandoned. Mao resigns as CCP chairman and is succeeded by Liu Shaoqi.

1959 Revolt in Tibet is put down and the Dalai Lama flees to India, where he sets up a government-in-exile.

1960 Sino-Soviet split as Mao considers that the Soviet Revolution has lost its way.

1961–65 A more pragmatic economic approach is adopted, led by Liu and Deng Xiaoping.

1962 Border conflict between China and India leaves 2,000 dead and China in continued occupation of the disputed Himalayan region of Aksai Chin.

1964 Mao’s Little Red Book, containing a collection of his sayings, is first published. China conducts its first test of a nuclear weapon in the Lop Nur desert.

1966 The Cultural Revolution is initiated by Mao to restore his supreme power. It is intended to last 10 years. Schools are shut down and the youthful Red Guards are encouraged to attack all authority and bourgeois ideas. Party officials and community leaders are subjected to public criticism and humiliation as work all but grinds to a halt, and many thousands die. The cult of personality surrounding Mao is intensified and the Red Guards splinter into factions, each claiming to represent the will of Mao.

1966–68 Campaign against the “Four Olds”: old ideas, old customs, old culture, old habits. Temples are ransacked, books are burned, and intellectuals are persecuted. By 1968, industrial production has dipped to barely 12 percent of the levels of 1966.

1967 Army intervenes to restore order amid countrywide chaos. The Red Guards

are dispersed as the Cultural Revolution is brought to an end. Liu and Deng are purged from the party.

1969 Mao regains chair of the CCP. Lin Biao is designated his successor, but is quickly attacked by Mao. Chinese and Soviet forces clash on an island in the Ussuri river.

1970 China launches its first satellite, Dong Fang Hong I (The East is Red I).

1971 Lin Biao dies in plane crash.

1972 US President Nixon visits China and meets Mao, as a more open foreign policy is initiated by Zhou Enlai.

1973 Mao’s wife Jiang Qing, Zhang Chunqiu, and other “Gang of Four” members are elected to the CCP politburo. Deng Xiaoping rehabilitated.

1976 Zhou Enlai dies. Mao strips Deng of all his posts. Following a long period of illness, Mao dies at age 82. On his death, the Gang of Four attempt to seize power, but is thwarted by supporters of Deng. The Gang of Four is arrested (and put on trial in 1981). A massive earthquake at Tangshan in Hebei province leaves at least 250,000 dead.

1977 Deng regains party posts and begins to extend power base.

1978 Economic modernization launched. Farmers are allowed to farm for profit.

1978–79 The Democracy Wall movement in Beijing provides an outlet for protesters seeking greater democratic freedom during a period known as the “Beijing Spring.” Criticism of the Gang of Four and acknowledged past mistakes

is encouraged, but when the present system is criticized, the Wall is closed.

1979 Diplomatic relations are established with the US and President Jimmy Carter visits China. Sino-Vietnamese War leaves 80,000 dead. Pinyin is adopted as the official system of transcribing Chinese into Latin alphabets.

1980 Deng emerges as China’s paramount leader. Economic reform gathers pace, but hopes for political change are suppressed. First Special Economic Zone (SEZ) established in Shenzhen. A “one child” family planning policy is adopted at a national level.

1984 Industrial reforms announced.

1986–90 Implementation of Open-Door policy to encourage foreign trade and investment.

1987 CCP secretary general Hu Yaobang is forced to resign over his liberal stance and moves to rehabilitate victims of the Cultural Revolution.

1989 Prodemocracy demonstrations in Tiananmen Square, which are initially aimed at the posthumous rehabilitation of Hu Yaobang. After initial hesitation by the government, the uprising is ordered to be crushed by the army, with the loss of 1,000–5,000 lives. Beijing is placed under martial law and China briefly faces international isolation.

1990 Shanghai stock exchange restarts operations after a 41-year closure.

1992 China ratifies the Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty. Russia and China sign a declaration restoring friendly ties.

DECISIVE MOMENT

LHASA UPRISING, 1959

On March 10, 1959, simmering tension between Tibetans and their Chinese rulers exploded in an uprising in the Tibetan capital, Lhasa. Thousands took to the streets surrounding the Potala Palace (below) to protest against the influx of Chinese settlers, which had begun when Chinese troops entered eastern Tibet in October 1950.

Tibet had declared its independence in 1911 when the Manchu had fallen, and governed itself for 40 years, but its poorly equipped army had been no match for the invading Chinese in 1950. This proved true again and the uprising was crushed, leaving thousands dead. The Dalai Lama, spiritual leader

of Tibet, was forced to flee across the Himalayas on foot. He set up a government-in-exile in India and has campaigned for an independent Tibet ever since.

Following the uprising, the Chinese government, which formally recognizes Tibet as an autonomous region, began a crackdown on Tibetan religion and culture. In the 1970s, repression eased but riots broke out again in the late 1980s and martial law was imposed in 1988.

